

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART ONE · STORY

CHAPTER 3 · POINT OF VIEW

*Whose eyes the story lends you, and what it costs to
borrow them.*

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

Rear Window · 1954 · 112 min · dir. Alfred Hitchcock · Paramount

*This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some
information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you
press play" and resume after the credits.*

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner.

*Two films about the act of watching, built from opposite ends of the lens. In *Rear Window* you are the watcher: you sit in one man's chair, you see what he sees, and the film almost never lets you leave the room. In *The Truman Show* you are the audience of a man being watched by everyone, and the film keeps swapping whose eyes you are using — his, the hidden cameras', the control room's, the viewers' at home.*

One locks the point of view down tighter than almost any film ever made. The other splits it five ways. Both end with somebody looking straight back.

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

REAR WINDOW

1954 · 112 min · dir. Alfred Hitchcock · Paramount

A photographer stuck at home with a broken leg starts watching his neighbours across the courtyard, and becomes sure one of them has committed murder.

Why it is on the ballot. It is the purest point-of-view experiment in the Hollywood canon. For almost two hours the camera stays inside one apartment and shows you what one man in a wheelchair can see. Everything you know, you know because he looked.

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

THE WHOLE WORLD OF THE FILM IS ONE SET

The courtyard was built as a single composite set on Paramount's Stage 18, roughly 185 feet long and 98 feet wide, holding 31 apartments. The stage floor was dug out so the courtyard sat below stage level and Jeff's second-floor window looked down on it from ground level. Sources disagree on how many apartments were fully furnished: the studio's own notes say eight, other accounts say twelve.

THE NEIGHBOURS COULD NOT HEAR THE DIRECTOR

Hitchcock stayed in Jeff's apartment and cued the actors across the courtyard by short-wave radio, through flesh-coloured earpieces they wore on camera.

IT DISAPPEARED FOR A DECADE

The rights to five Hitchcock films, *Rear Window* among them, reverted to him, and he kept them out of circulation. They became known as the "Lost Hitchcocks." *Rear Window* only came back in a Universal re-release in October 1983, three years after his death.

WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

FIRST THREE MINUTES

The story before a word is spoken

The blinds rise with the credits. The camera drifts across the courtyard, finds a thermometer in the nineties, a sleeping man, a signed plaster cast, a smashed camera, a photograph of a racing crash, a magazine cover. You know who he is, what he does and how he got hurt before anybody speaks.

Why it matters: The film teaches you its rule in the first shot. The camera shows you things, and you do the reading.

EVERY TIME JEFF LOOKS

Look, see, react

Watch the pattern: a close-up of Jeff looking, a shot of what he sees, then his face again. Hitchcock described that three-part structure to François Truffaut as “the purest expression of a cinematic idea.”

Why it matters: The neighbours never change. What changes is his face, and the meaning you read into it.

WHILE JEFF IS ASLEEP

The film cheats, once

In the small hours the camera pans away from the sleeping Jeff on its own and shows Thorwald leaving the building with a woman. Jeff never sees it.

Why it matters: It is the film’s one real break from its own rule, and it works against his theory at the exact moment you are committing to it. Ask yourself afterwards whether the film lied to him, or told the truth to you.

Across the courtyard, a man turns his head and looks straight down the lens.

Why it matters: For the whole film, looking has been one way. The moment the watched one looks back, the rules break, and the next ten minutes come for the room you have been sitting in.

03

AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

OPEN

The climax borrows someone else's eyes

During the flashbulb scene the film cuts four times to Thorwald's dazzled vision, rendered through a red filter. It is one of the only times the camera belongs to somebody other than Jeff, and the film saves it for the moment he is most defenceless.

OPEN

It came from a pulp story, and the women were invented

The source is Cornell Woolrich's "It Had to Be Murder," published in *Dime Detective* in February 1942. There is no Lisa in it and no Stella. Screenwriter John Michael Hayes built both women out of the story's male houseman. The film's biggest addition is the person who actually does the dangerous part.

OPEN

The courtyard had its own weather department

The set was lit with a reported thousand-plus units and fitted with a sprinkler system for the thunderstorm. Jeff's world, like Truman's, was a place where somebody else controlled the sun and the rain. Hitchcock's cameo is inside it: he is the man winding the clock in the songwriter's apartment.

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- 01 Jeff never leaves his chair, and neither do you. By the end, is the film on the side of watching, or is it quietly judging him, and you?
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- 02 If the neighbour had turned out to be innocent, would the film still work? What would it be about then?
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- 03 Lisa takes every real risk in the film. So whose film is this?
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Where to watch

Find it here → [Rear Window on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: AFI Catalog · TCM · American Cinematographer · Yale Film Archive

THE LESSON

THE CAMERA DOESN'T LIE

HENRY JAMES DESCRIBED WHAT HE WAS DOING

In the prefaces he wrote for the New York Edition of his novels, published 1907 to 1909, Henry James explained his habit of telling a story through one character's consciousness — what he called a "centre" or a "reflector." It was a working novelist describing his own method, and he never used the phrase "point of view" for it.

PERCY LUBBOCK TURNED IT INTO A LAW

In 1921 the critic Percy Lubbock, who was James's literary executor, published *The Craft of Fiction* and made that habit the whole art: "The whole intricate question of method, in the craft of fiction, I take to be governed by the question of the point of view." The phrase is his, not James's. From there it became a classroom rule, and eventually "show, don't tell." One novelist's working method hardened into the standard for everyone.

HOLLYWOOD'S VERSION: THE CAMERA TELLS THE TRUTH

Film grew its own form of the rule. What the camera shows you, happened. In 1950 Alfred Hitchcock broke it in *Stage Fright*, opening with a flashback that turns out to be a lie. Audiences felt cheated, and he later called it one of his biggest mistakes. Four years later he made *Rear Window*, where the camera almost never shows you anything Jeff did not see.

THREE WAYS A FILM CAN LEND YOU ITS EYES

ONE

RESTRICTED

You know only what one character knows, and you find things out when they do.

Rear Window · Memento · Parasite's first half

TWO

UNRESTRICTED

The film shows you more than any character knows, and the tension comes from watching them walk into it.

Psycho · Jaws · The Shining

THREE

SUBJECTIVE

The camera becomes a character's eyes, for a shot or for a whole film.

Lady in the Lake · Hardcore Henry · found footage

The Truman Show is a fourth case: a film that passes the camera between characters until you keep changing sides.

ONE PIECE OF VOCABULARY

Hitchcock separated **surprise** from **suspense** using a bomb under a table. If it simply explodes, the audience gets a shock. If they were shown the bomb first, the same scene becomes unbearable: "In the first case we have given the public fifteen seconds of surprise at the moment of the explosion. In the second we have provided them with fifteen minutes of suspense." The only thing that changed is what the point of view let them know.

WHY THESE FILMS

Chapter 1 was the shape of a story and chapter 2 was its clock. This chapter is the narrator: who is holding the camera, and whether you trust them. One film keeps you in one chair. The other hands you around a room full of watchers until you realise you are one of them.

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from the AFI Catalog, TCM, American Cinematographer, the Academy's awards database, the Yale Film Archive and contemporary reporting. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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